

The slur-epithet direction: the case of Italian

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Abstract: We offer a new empirical argument from Italian in favor of the thesis that epithets (both in simple and binominal configurations) contain an indexical ingredient. The argument is based on the observation that Italian, unlike Spanish or English, forces the use of weak demonstratives with epithets. The distribution of these demonstratives, as we illustrate, correlates with the presence of a type of empty nominal anaphor. Thus, epithets must be one instance of this type, with which they form a natural class. Slurs, instead, are regular nominal heads in the extended projections of DPs or related nominal phrases. Consequently, they are compatible with the full array of determiner heads that the language allows. From this perspective, the difference between epithets (i.e., pure expressives) and slurs (mixed expressives) boils down to a difference in syntactic structure. We argue that epithets, particularly those derived from slur words, are merged in the functional spine of a pronominal DP, whose nominal head is instantiated by a mere index for an assignment function ranging over individuals. We conclude by showing the importance of the weak demonstrative test to distinguish at least two types of qualitative binominal constructions in Italian.

Keywords: epithets, slurs, demonstratives, empty nouns, Italian

1 Introduction

In Spanish, pejorative expressions like *puto* ‘homosexual_{PEJ}’ or *puta* ‘prostitute_{PEJ}’ can be used either as canonical slur words (1) (McCready 2010) or as epithets (2) (Potts 2005). In both cases, the expression can be headed by any type of determiner, such as articles or demonstratives:¹

(1) Spanish

- a. *Andrés es {el/este/aquel} puto de arriba.*
Andrés is the/this/that homosexual_{PEJ} of upstairs
‘Andrés is the/this/that *f...* living upstairs.’
- b. *Ana es {la/esta/aquella} puta de Rosario.*
Ana is the/this/that prostitute_{PEJ} of Rosario
‘Ana is the/this/that *wh...* from Rosario’

- (2) a. *Ese es el/ese puto de Andrés.*
that is the/that EPITHET of Andrés
‘That one is that *f...* Andrés.’
- b. *Esa es la/esa puta de Ana.*
that is the/that EPITHET of Ana
‘That one is the/that *wh...* Ana.’

If we compare (1-2) with their Italian counterpart, an interesting contrast emerges: while slurs can occur with any determiner, as in Spanish (3), epithets typically occur with the distal demonstrative *quel* (‘that’), which does not carry a deictic value in this case (we refer to it as “weak demonstrative”). Other determiners like articles are much more restricted, and they are usually only accepted in some regional variety, where they occur in specific configurations (4):²

¹ Note that our use of the term *slur* is equivalent to the term *pejorative* used by McCready (2010). We prefer to keep the more general term *pejorative* for both slurs and epithets.

² We have consulted various colleagues from different areas of Italy about the use of articles with epithets. What emerges is that it is considered more acceptable from Rome southwards, while it is more restricted in most of the country (North, Tuscany, Sardinia and Sicily). In any case, there are some configurations in which nobody seems to accept the use of the article, e.g. in (i), where the N on the right of the epithet has an indefinite article (cf. Massaro 2023, *to appear* for an overview of the different possibilities attested in Romance and beyond):

(i) *{*L'/quell'} idiota di un falegname ha sbagliato di nuovo!*
the/that idiot of a carpenter has failed again
‘The carpenter, that idiot, has made again an error!’

For our concerns, the existence of a variety of Italian in which the article is possible with epithets is not problematic, because these speakers behave like Spanish speakers. What is crucial for us is that at least for some varieties of Italian

(3) Italian

a. *Gianni è {il/questo/quel} frocio a destra.*
 Gianni is the/this/that homosexual_{PEJ} at right
 ‘Gianni is the/this/that *f...* on the right.’

b. *Lucia è {la/questa/quella} zoccola di Milano.*
 Lucia is the/this/that prostitute_{PEJ} of Milan
 ‘Lucia is the/this/that *wh...* from Milan

(4) a. *Questo è {??il/quel} frocio di Carlo.*
 this is the/that EPITHET of Andrés
 ‘This is Carlo, the *f...*’

b. *Questa è {??la/quella} zoccola di Lucia.*
 this is the/that EPITHET of Lucia
 ‘This is Lucia, the *wh...*’

To capture this difference, we first must consider the difference between slurs and epithets more in general. A crucial distinction between the two types of expressives is that whereas slurs are mixed terms with both an expressive and a descriptive component, epithets are pure expressive items, with no contribution to the truth-conditional dimension (see Gutzmann 2015, 2019 for a taxonomy in a bidimensional framework). Following Orlando & Saab (2020b), we assume that the expressive dimension for both terms is modelled as a stereotype. The paradigm in (1-4) illustrates this difference. Thus, in the examples in (1) and (3), the slur word has a predicative import according to which someone is classified as a homosexual and a prostitute, respectively. In addition, they also introduce a stereotype regarding homosexuals and prostitutes, which depending on pragmatic uses reveals the homophobic or misogynistic profile of the speaker. The predicative import is lost in the examples in (2) and (4), in which only the expressive dimension survives.

A crucial question is why and how a slur word, say *puto* in (2a), loses its predicative import when occurring as an epithet. In a series of works, Saab (2022b, 2025a,b) and Orlando & Saab (2020a) argue that the source of the difference is essentially syntactic. The idea is that the same lexical

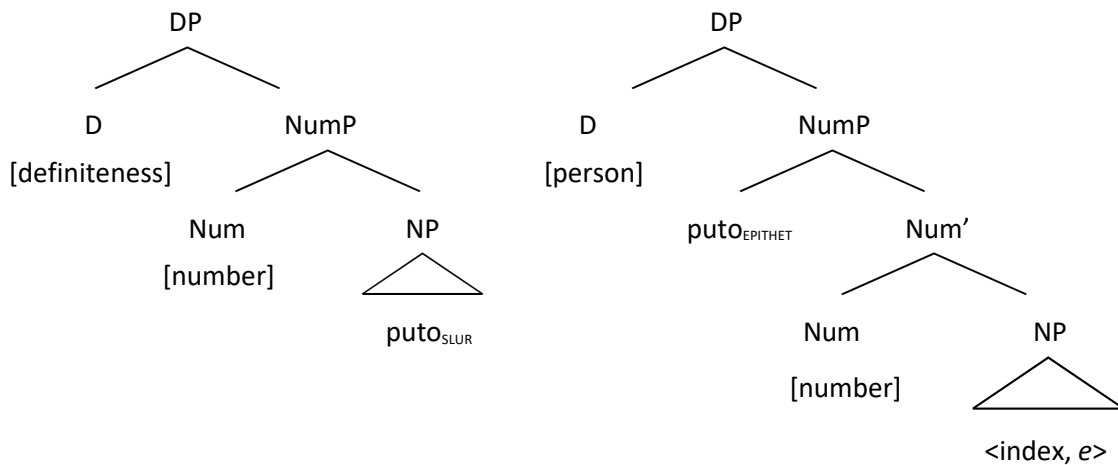
the demonstrative is the only possibility in all cases. This paper is thus based on the grammar of the speakers who reject the use of articles with epithets, and the judgements given in the examples refer to this grammar.

item can have a predicative and a non-predicative occurrence, with the latter called its *recycling position*.³ This is stated in the following thesis from Saab (2022b) and (2025a):

- (5) Recycling thesis:⁴ Epithets are merged in a non-predicative position, in the extended projection of an indexical DP.

The trees below illustrate the thesis with the slur and the epithet in (1a) and (2a), respectively. In the tree in (6a), the slur word is merged as a common noun; in this position, it denotes the set of homosexual people at the representational or truth-conditional dimension and conventionally communicates a stereotype at the expressive or non-representational dimension. Instead, epithets are directly merged in a non-predicative position, so they only communicate the relevant stereotype at the expressive dimension; i.e., they are expletives at the truth-conditional dimension. We assume that the non-predicative position in (6b) is Spec,NumP, but it could be another position in the functional spine of DPs.

- (6) a. The representational syntax of slurs: b. The non-representational syntax of epithets:



³ There is an interesting connection between expressive recycling and well-known processes of grammaticalization. For a given slur to become an epithet not only is the syntactic position relevant, but also some lexical impoverishment of the descriptive dimension of the slur. In this study, we will only be concerned with the syntactic aspects of recycling.

⁴ This notion of *recycling* should not be confused with the *recycling* operation discussed in Ritter & Wiltschko (2025), which consists of “a movement operation in which a given form is inserted in one position, where it receives an interpretation, and is subsequently moved into a higher position, where it receives a new interpretation” (Ritter & Wiltschko 2025: 673). Their idea is inspired by the more general notion of *value recycling* introduced in Mezhevich (2008), although Ritter & Wiltschko focus on movement operations within the interactional spine of nominals. For instance, they explain the use of formal *vous* ‘you_{FORMAL}’ in French as the result of recycling a plural pronoun in a higher interactional position, in which registered flavors are encoded. Our sense of recycling is different as it does not imply any movement operation or semantic reinterpretation. As noted in footnote 3, our notion is closer to the traditional notion of grammaticalization or expletivization.

These structures amount to the following two (simplified) LFs. Following McCready (2010), we use the diamond and the bullet to distinguish mixed expressives from pure ones, respectively (E = epithet, S = slur):

- (7) Spanish
El puto_{E/S} llegó tarde.
 the homosexual arrived late
 ‘The *f...*/That *f...* arrived late.’

Slur interpretation: *the homosexual* arrived late ♦ a homosexual stereotype is in force in *c*

Epithet interpretation: *he* arrived late • homosexual-stereotype(*x*)

As already observed, both slurs and epithets have an expressive dimension, which is represented as a certain type of stereotype at the right of the diamond and the bullet in (7). Thus, the difference between the two interpretations must be detected at the left of each of the diamond and the bullet, where slurs are represented as nominal predicates and epithets as pronominal expressions.

Now, the main goal of this paper is to present new evidence from Italian in favor of an indexical component in epithets. As shown in (4), unlike Spanish and related Romance languages, Italian epithets require the presence of the weak demonstrative *quel* ‘that’ (see below). As we will see, the exclusive use of the demonstrative with epithets undoubtedly diagnoses the presence of the indexical ingredient in (4). The paper is structured as follows. In section 2, following the previous work already mentioned, we offer an overview of the recycling thesis and its implementation in Spanish and English. In section 3, we highlight the importance of the Italian evidence in the domain of slurs and epithets. In a nutshell, we show that the use of the demonstrative in examples like (4) is related to the presence of empty nominals/ellipsis in the language. Those empty nominals denote indexes for assignment functions ranging over individuals, i.e., they are indexicals. In section 4, we extend the indexical analysis proposed for English and Spanish to Italian and discuss the correlation between weak demonstratives and empty nouns in qualitative binominals containing epithets. Binominals are key to the present discussion because they allow us to clearly distinguish between slurs and epithets, since only the latter are allowed in binominals. In the same section, we briefly comment on another type of Italian binominals, which do not require the demonstrative (i.e., the *cazzo*-construction). Our results point to a new taxonomy of qualitative binominal DPs, which includes two basic types, namely: (i) those that contain the indexical ingredient, and (ii) those that do not.

2 A systematic syntactic ambiguity: previous evidence from Spanish and English

Let's consider the ambiguity in (7) again, repeated as (8):

- (8) *El puto_{E/S} llegó tarde.*
 the f... arrived late

Slur interpretation: *the homosexual* arrived late ♦ a homosexual stereotype is in force in c

Epithet interpretation: *he* arrived late • homosexual-stereotype(x)

According to the representations provided below (8), the item *puto* is interpreted either as a mixed slur or as an epithet, i.e., as a mere insult. On this second interpretation, the DP *el puto* only denotes the value of a given assignment function. In Orlando & Saab (2020a) and a series of related works by the same authors, such an ambiguity has a structural source. In this section, we offer an overview of the diagnostics provided by Orlando & Saab to set the background for the Italian facts relevant to the present study.

There are at least five quite robust tests that allow us to disambiguate the two relevant readings in (8). They concern Principle-C and antilogophoricity effects, intensification of the expression, its use in a binominal construction and in contexts of nominal ellipsis, and restrictive modification.

The first test has to do with the distribution of slurs and epithets in antilogophoric and Principle-C environments. There is a long-standing debate regarding the anaphoric nature of epithets. Jackendoff (1972) famously claimed that they have the distribution of pronouns. His argument is based on the interpretation of epithets in cases like (9) (antecedents underlined):

- (9) a. *I wanted Charlie to help me, but the bastard wouldn't do it.*
 b. *Irving was besieged by a horde of bills and the poor guy couldn't pay them.*
 c. *Although the bum tried to hit me, I can't really get too mad at Harry.*

(Jackendoff 1972: 110)

A rule of pronominalization changing the relevant DPs for mere pronouns (e.g., *the bastard* → *he*) would fail at capturing the expressive content of epithets. Therefore, in order to account for the coreference patterns between epithets and their corresponding antecedents in each of the relevant sentences in (9), Jackendoff proposes to treat epithets as a class of “special pronouns”,

which he called “pronominal epithets” (Jackendoff 1972: 110-111). Yet, Lasnik (1976) noticed that this view fails to account for the ungrammatical sentences in (10):

- (10) a. *John realizes that the sissy is going to lose.
 b. *He realizes that the sissy is going to lose.
 c. *The sissy realizes that the sissy is going to lose. (Lasnik 1976: 11)

Changing the embedded epithet for a “normal” pronoun would make all the intended coreferences perfectly felicitous (e.g., John realizes that *he*...). It seems, then, that epithets behave as R-expressions (i.e., definite descriptions or proper names), as witnessed by the comparison between (10) and (11), that contains R-expressions in the embedded position:

- (11) a. *John realizes that John/the lawyer is going to lose.
 b. *He realizes that John/the lawyer is going to lose.
 c. *The sissy realizes that John/the lawyer is going to lose.

Because of this type of empirical consideration, Lasnik treats epithets and R-expressions as similar referential expressions subject to his no-coreference rule, i.e., the predecessor of Principle-C in Binding Theory. In principle, the new approach covers both the facts in (9) and (10), since the antecedents *c*-command the epithets in (10) but not in (9), allowing thus co-reference but not binding in the latter (binding requires *c*-command). The *c*-command relations in (10), instead, force binding in a clear infraction of Principle-C in Binding Theory (i.e., R-expressions must be free (not bound) in their governing category).

Yet, as originally noted by Dubinsky & Hamilton (1998), the R-expression approach to epithets does not account for the following contrasts:

- (12) a. *John_i ran over a man (who was) trying to give the idiot_i/ *John_i directions.*
 b. *Through an accumulation of slip-ups, John_i (inadvertently) led his students to conclude that the idiot_i/ *John_i couldn't teach.*

(adapted from Dubinsky & Hamilton 1998: 689)

Here, the antecedent *John* can co-refer with the epithet but not with the R-expression. As is clear, the impossibility of co-reference with R-expressions follows as standard violations of Principle-C, but the pattern with epithets is totally unexpected under Lasnik's approach. For this reason, Dubinsky & Hamilton recover Jackendoff's original insight that epithets are “special pronouns” and make sense of their peculiarities through the introduction of an antilogophoric restriction in the distribution of epithets.

- (13) Antilogophoricity constraint for epithets: An epithet must not be anteceded by an individual from whose perspective the attributive content of the epithet is evaluated.

(Dubinsky & Hamilton 1998: 689)

The constraint is violated in (10) but not in (12), in which there is no coincidence between the perspective-bearer and the antecedent, making pronominal coreference legit.⁵

As noted by Orlando & Saab (2020a), it is possible to disambiguate the slur and epithetic readings in (8) by making use of antilogophoric environments in the favored sense. On this view, it is correctly predicted that a syntactic and semantic environment like (14a) cannot tolerate either slurs or epithets. The sentence (14a) is ruled out as a standard infraction of Principle-C under the slur reading, but as an antilogophoricity constraint violation under the epithetic reading. Now, if we manipulate the antilogophoric environment by changing the perspective-bearer but maintaining the relevant *c*-command dependency, we predict that epithets, but not slurs, could co-refer with their antecedent. As (14b) shows, the prediction is borne out:

- (14) a. **/#Andrés_i dijo que [el puto_{E/S}]_i llegó tarde.*
 Andrés said that the EPITHET/SLUR arrived late
 ‘Andrés said that the [EPITHET/*f*...] arrived late.’
- b. *Andrés es tan extrovertido que todos piensan que*
 Andrés_i is so outgoing that everyone thinks that
*[el puto_{E/*S}]_i se va a meter en problemas con la policía.*
 the EPITHET/SLUR SE goes to put in troubles with the police
 ‘Andrés_i is so outgoing that everyone thinks that the [EPITHET/**SLUR*]_i is going to get in trouble with the police.’

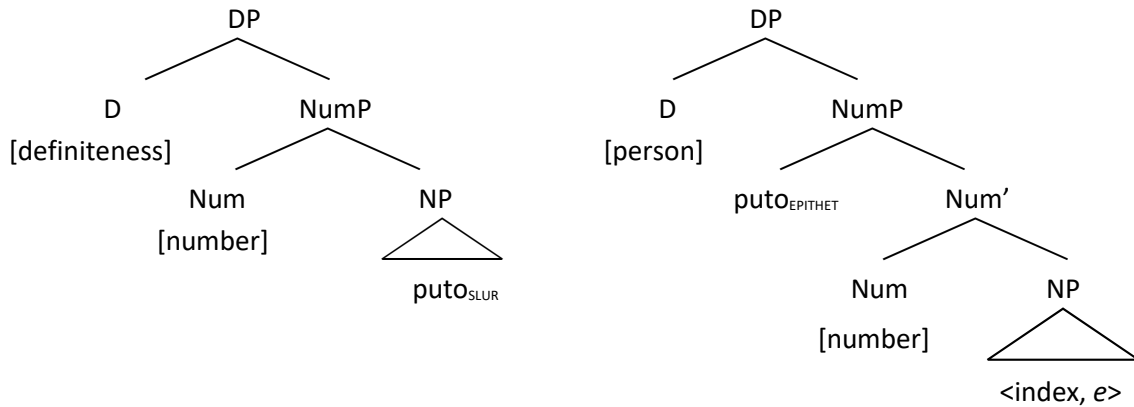
Assuming that in its slur occurrence *puto* has the syntax in (6a) (repeated as (15a)) and the epithet has the syntax in (6b) (repeated as (15b)), we capture the contrasts in (14).

⁵ It is not clear how to account for the infelicitous coreference in (i), in particular, under a possible *de re* reading of the attitude predicate, according to which the attitude-bearer is the speaker and not the antecedent:

(i) **John_i believes that [the idiot]_i cannot do it.*

We will leave this problem unresolved here, as it is orthogonal to our main point in this study.

- (15) a. The representational syntax of slurs: b. The non-representational syntax of epithets:



In addition to differences in co-reference constraints, the two readings can also be disambiguated through additional tests: the second test concerns intensifiers like *muy* 'very', which can only modify epithets, not slurs:⁶

- (16) *El muy puto_{E/*S} llegó tarde.*
 the very EPITHET/*SLUR arrived late
 'That complete f... arrived late.'

Third, qualitative binominals also disambiguate in favor of the epithetic readings (see also the examples in (2)). So, if we change the subject DP in (8) for a qualitative binominal, the predicative reading, typical of slur words, vanishes. Put differently, the word *puto* in (17) can only be interpreted as an epithet:

- (17) *El puto_{E/*S} de Andrés llegó tarde.*
 the EPITHET/*SLUR of Andrés arrived late
 'That f... Andrés arrived late.'

The last two tests disambiguate in the opposite direction. So, the analyses in (15) predict that only slurs can be subject to canonical NP-ellipsis, a deletion operation that targets NPs, with exclusion of their extended functional projections (see Saab 2019). Since slurs head regular NPs, there is no reason why they cannot be subject to nominal ellipsis. As illustrated in (18a), the prediction is borne out; slurs can be elided by NP-ellipsis. This is not the case with epithets, which do not head any extended DP projection. The example in (18b) shows that an indubitable

⁶ Noun intensification must not be confused with degree modification, which in Spanish can also be expressed by *muy* 'very'. Indeed, note that the epithet rejects pure degree modifiers (e.g., **demasiado/poco/bastante puto* 'too/little/enough EPITHET') typically attested with degree adjectives.

occurrence of an epithet in qualitative binominal environments like those in (17) cannot be elided, a fact that robustly points out to the conclusion that epithets are not canonical nominal heads (<...> = elliptical site).

- (18) a. *el puto de al lado y el <puto> de arriba*
 the SLUR of to.the side and the SLUR of upstairs
 ‘the f... next doors and the one living upstairs....’
- b. **el puto de Andrés y el <puto> de Pablo*
 the EPITHET of Andrés and the EPITHET of Pablo

Finally, consider restrictive modification. As expected, only slurs, i.e., true nominal predicates, allow for canonical modification by, say, restrictive adjectives:

- (19) a. *el puto inteligente de arriba*
 the SLUR intelligent of upstairs
 ‘the intelligent f... living upstairs’
- b. **el puto inteligente de Andrés*
 the EPITHET intelligent of Andrés

Table 1 summarizes the main differences between epithets and slurs discussed so far.

Table 1: Epithets vs Slurs

Syntactic class	Syntactic position	Tests				
		Binding effects	Intensification	Binominal occurrence	Nominal ellipsis	Restrictive modification
Epithet	Spec,NumP	<i>antilogophoric</i>	<i>yes</i>	<i>yes</i>	<i>no</i>	<i>no</i>
Slur	NP head	<i>Principle-C</i>	<i>no</i>	<i>no</i>	<i>yes</i>	<i>yes</i>

Importantly, as Orlando & Saab (2020a) show, the ambiguity also arises in other languages. Consider English, where the same ambiguity in (8) arises, witness (20):

- (20) *That wh..._{E/S} arrived late at the party.*
- a. Slur interpretation: That prostitute arrived late at the party ♦ a misogynistic stereotype is in force in *c*
- b. Epithet interpretation: She (namely, the woman referred to in the context of utterance) arrived late to the party • misogynistic-stereotype(*g*(she))

Like in Spanish, antilogophoricity environments can be used to disambiguate between the two readings. In (21a), again, there is no way to embed either a slur or an epithet, because of Principle-C and the antilogophoric restriction, respectively. Now, in the sentence in (21b), in which

antilogophoricity is avoided, a DP containing an epithet can be used with the intended coreference, but a slur DP is banned:

(21) Antilogophoricity/Principle-C effects (Orlando & Saab 2020a):

- a. **/#Alice_i said that [the wh..._{E/S}]_i had arrived late.*
- b. *Mia_i is so talkative that everybody thinks that [the wh..._E]_i will get into trouble with the police.*

Also like in Spanish, only epithets can be intensified:

(22) Intensification:

- That complete wh..._E arrived late.* (Orlando & Saab 2020a)

As shown in Saab (2025a), although English does not have NP-ellipsis of the Spanish type, *one* anaphora can also be used as a similar diagnostic to disambiguate in favor of the slur reading. Thus, in (23a) a slur can be replaced by the nominal anaphora *one*. The same replacement is impossible for an indubitable occurrence of an epithet like *that wh... Mary*, since, as we already have seen, epithets do not head the lexical domain of extended DP projections.⁷

(23) One-anaphora:

- a. *I'm talking about that annoying wh..._S, not this charming one.*
- b. **that annoying wh..._E Anne and this charming one Mary*

In summary, the attested ambiguity of examples like (8) in Spanish or (20) in English can be derived as a case of structural ambiguity. Concretely, the same word can occur either as a nominal predicate heading the lexical layer of a given extended DP or as a nominal modifier, merged in the functional spine of the extended projection of a DP headed by a mere index subject to an assignment function. In the next section, we focus on Italian, a language that provides robust evidence for the distinction just made.

3 Italian

In this section, we offer our main empirical argument in favor of the indexical analysis for epithets based on the distribution of weak demonstratives in Italian epithets. In §3.1, we first show that the same ambiguity observed for Spanish (8) and English (20) can be detected in Italian

⁷ Note that the test of binominal expression cannot be carried out for independent reasons, because English does not allow structures of this type.

through the same tests we used in the previous section. In §3.2, we discuss in more detail the distribution of weak demonstratives in Italian following recent work by Cardinaletti (2024) and Pescarini (2024). As we will see, there is a robust correlation between this type of demonstratives and empty nouns, including empty indexical nouns.

3.1 Epithets and slurs in Italian

In Italian, a sentence like (8) above can be formulated by using either a definite article or a demonstrative. Here is a similar example:

- (24) Italian
 È arrivata {la /quella} puttana_{S/E}.
 is arrived the/that prostitute_{PEJ./EPITHET}
 ‘The/that wh... has arrived.’

However, the distribution of the article and the demonstrative pronoun does not completely overlap: when *puttana* ‘prostitute.PEJ’ is used as a slur, both an article and a demonstrative can be used. When it has an epithet reading, only the distal demonstrative *quello* is used. The examples in (25) show the difference:⁸

- (25) a. È arrivata {la/una/questa/quella} puttana_S.
 is arrived the/a/this/that prostitute_{PEJ}
 ‘The/that wh... has arrived.’
 b. È arrivata {*la/*una/*questa/quella} puttana_E.
 is arrived the/a/this/that EPITHET
 ‘The wh... has arrived.’

Note that the demonstrative *quella* in (25b) does not carry a deictic value (or it only very marginally does so): it is a “weak” demonstrative.⁹ “True” demonstratives (with deictic value) are

⁸ Note that when *questo* ‘this’ and *quel* ‘that’ are used as “true” deictic demonstratives (25a), they behave like a definite determiner of D category. In what follows, for ease of exposition we only contrast the definite article with the weak demonstrative, without considering “true” demonstratives.

⁹ Weak demonstratives used with epithets (as in (25b)) are reminiscent of Pescarini’s (2024) “light demonstratives”, which are also used in non-deictic contexts: for example, in free relatives (i) and, crucially, when NP-ellipsis occurs (ii). We come back to NP-ellipsis in §3.2.

(i) Dimmi quello che pensi.
 tell.IMP=me that.DEM that.COMP think.2SG
 ‘Tell me what you’re thinking.’

(ii) Ho visto il figlio di Gianni, non quello <figlio> di Luca.

ruled out in epithets, as shown by the fact that the proximal demonstrative *questa* (which is always deictic) is ungrammatical in (25b), unlike in (25a). As a matter of fact, in the case of slurs any determiner is acceptable, if it is compatible with the context. Thus, Italian neatly differs from Spanish and English, in which the article is used with both slurs and epithets; therefore, in these languages many sentences are ambiguous between the two readings. In Italian, instead, the use of the article can be used as a test to distinguish between epithets and slurs.

Robust evidence for the complementary distribution of articles and weak demonstratives is provided by binominals, which, as we have seen, require an epithet (Test 3; cf. (4) above): as example (26) shows, in Italian they reject the presence of the definite article, unlike in Spanish (see Property #3 below):¹⁰

- (26) {*quella*/**la*} *puttana*_{E/*S} *di una professoressa*
 {that.F.SG/the.F.SG} EPITHET of a professor
 ‘the professor, a *wh...*’

The example (26) differs from (24) because the latter is in principle compatible with both an epithet and a slur reading (modulo the use of the article or the demonstrative), while (26) has,

have.1SG seen the son of Gianni not that son of Luca
 ‘I saw Gianni’s son, not Luca’s.’

In addition to their non-deictic value, weak and light demonstratives share the fact that they both correspond, in Spanish, to definite articles, and that they need not be anaphoric (i.e., they do not need to have been already introduced in the discourse). By contrast, weak demonstratives differ from light demonstratives because:

- light demonstratives always display the full forms *quello* and *quelli* (in the masculine), while weak demonstratives have the short forms *quel* and *quei* (like true demonstratives);
- light and weak demonstratives can be used in different types of binominal constructions: those that feature a light demonstrative require an intonational break after the noun, and the following PP takes a bare noun as complement; binominal constructions with weak demonstratives (which are the topic of this paper) have no intonational break, and the PP selects a DP, cf. (iii-iv), and see also (26) and the discussion about binominals below:

- (iii) *quello* *frocio*, *di cameriere*
 that homosexual_{PEJ} of waiter
 ‘the f... one among the waiters.’
- (iv) *quel* *frocio del cameriere*
 that EPITHET of-the waiter
 ‘the waiter, that f...’

We thank Diego Pescarini (p.c.) for discussing the differences between weak and light demonstratives with us. See §§ 4.1-2 for a first approach to the syntactic differences responsible for the different outcome of light and weak demonstratives.

¹⁰ Note that the article would be grammatical in (26) if *puttana* ‘bitch’ is interpreted as a slur, but in this case, we are forced to interpret *di una professoressa* ‘of a professor’ as a possessive PP, thus excluding the qualitative binominal interpretation. The same observation holds for examples (27-30).

for independent reasons, only the epithet reading (see §4.2). The same contrast can be seen with any other epithet that is derived from a slur, as (27-30) show:

- (27) a. *Ho visto {il/quel} fascio_{E/S}.*
 have.1SG seen the/that fascist_{E/S}
 ‘I’ve seen the/that fascist.’
- b. *Ho visto {*il/quel} fascio_{E/*S} del mio cugino.*
 have.1SG seen the/that EPITHET of-the my cousin
 ‘I’ve seen my cousin, that fascist’
- (28) a. *Ho visto {il/quel} frocio_{E/S}.*
 have.1SG seen the/that homosexual_{E/S}
 ‘The/that f... has arrived.’
- b. *Ho visto {*il/quel} frocio_{E/*S} del tuo amico.*
 have.1SG seen the/that EPITHET of-the your friend
 ‘your friend, that f...’
- (29) a. *Ho visto {il/quel} ne*ro_{E/S}.*
 have.1SG seen the/that black_{E/S}
 ‘The/that n... has arrived.’
- b. *Ho visto {*il/quel} ne*ro_{E/*S} di un negoziante.*
 have.1SG seen the/that EPITHET of a dealer
 ‘the dealer, that n...’
- (30) a. *Ho visto {la/quella} zoccola_{E/S}.*
 have.1SG seen the/that prostitute_{E/S}
 ‘The/that wh... has arrived.’
- b. *Ho visto {*la/quella} zoccola_{E/*S} della tua amica.*
 have.1SG seen the/that EPITHET of-the your friend
 ‘your friend, that wh...’

This observation is confirmed by the entire set of tests listed above (cf. Table 1). Consider first epithets: they can be used in antilogophoric environments (Test 1), and with an intensifier (Test 2). As described in §2, in antilogophoric environments the epithet cannot have as antecedent an individual from whose perspective the content of the epithet is evaluated. This is shown in (31): the use of a weak demonstrative triggers the epithet reading, which is allowed because the perspective is that of *tutti* ‘everyone’. The article is ungrammatical here, because it would turn the

interpretation of *stronzo* ‘asshole’ and *frocio* ‘homosexual.PEJ’ into a slur, and slurs cannot be coindexed with the subject of the main clause because of Principle-C:¹¹

- (31) a. *Marco è così antipatico che tutti pensano che*
 Marco is such unfriendly that everybody.PL think.3PL that
 {*lo / quello} *stronzo*_{E/*S} non troverà mai una fidanzata.
 the/ that EPITHET not find.FUT.3PL never a girlfriend
 ‘Marco is so unfriendly that we all think that the asshole will never find a girlfriend.’
- b. *Paolo se la tira così tanto che tutti pensano*
 Paolo REFL CL.ACC.F.SG takes so much that everybody.PL think.3PL
 che {*il/quel} *frocio*_{E/*S} rimarrà presto senza amici.
 that the/that EPITHET leave.FUT.3SG soon without friends
 ‘Paolo boasts so much that everyone thinks that f... will soon run out of friends.’

The examples in (32) illustrate Test 2 (intensification). If we add *grandissimo/a* ‘very big’, we are sure that we are dealing with an epithet and not with a slur. Again, only the weak demonstrative is allowed, while the definite article yields an ungrammatical result:¹²

- (32) a. *Non sopporto {*il/quel} grandissimo frocio*_{E/*S}.
 NEG stand.1SG the/that big.SUPERL EPITHET
 ‘I can’t stand that complete f...’
- b. *Mi ha chiamato {*la/quella} grandissima puttana*_{E/*S}.
 me has called the/that BIG.SUPERL EPITHET
 ‘That wh... called me yesterday.’

By contrast, in environments in which only slurs are admitted (Tests 4-5), the slur can be headed by the definite article and other D heads, while the weak demonstrative is barred. These contexts concern NP-ellipsis (Test 4) and restrictive modification of the slur (Test 5). Regarding NP-ellipsis, consider the contrast between (33a)/(34a) and (33b)/(34b): the first example shows ellipsis within a ‘regular’ DP, in which the slur is followed by a PP indicating origin. In these sentences, the overt slur is preceded by the definite article. In the case of the (b) examples, instead, two epithets are used, as witness by the fact that the first of them is headed by the weak

¹¹ More precisely, in (31a) the use of the article would trigger a literal interpretation of *stronzo* ‘piece of shit’, which of course could not be coindexed with the subject Marco.

¹² Note that in this case the use of the article is out for Southern speakers as well.

demonstrative.¹³ To make sure that this is indeed an epithet and not a slur (and thus to avoid its recovery as a slur with a ‘true’ demonstrative), we use two binominal expressions in (33b)/(34b):

- (33) a. *il crucco di Monaco e quello <crucco> di Amburgo*
 the German_{PEJ} of Munich and that German_{PEJ} of Hamburg
 ‘the kraut from Munich and that from Hamburg’
- b. **quel crucco di Hans e quello <crucco> di Dieter*
 that EPITHET of Hans and that <EPITHET> of Dieter
- (34) a. *la puttana di Napoli e quella <puttana> di Milano*
 the prostitute_{PEJ} of Naples and that prostitute_{PEJ} of Milan
 ‘the Neapolitan wh... and that from Milan’
- b. **quella puttana di Maria e quella <puttana> di Lisa*
 that EPITHET of Maria and that <EPITHET> of Lisa

As these examples show, the use of the weak demonstrative triggers the epithet interpretation ((b) examples), which is incompatible with ellipsis. This is expected if they are not ‘true’ nominal heads of DPs, unlike slurs.

The second property in which only slurs can be used is restrictive modification (Test 5). Here again, examples (35a)/(36a) feature a slur, which can be modified through a PP or an adjective. By contrast, the examples (35b)/(36b) show the use of an epithet (as attested by the fact that a binominal expression is used): in this case, the epithet cannot be restrictively modified. Note that, again, the use of the weak demonstrative *quel* turns the expression into an epithet, while the definite article is associated with the slur interpretation.¹⁴

- (35) a. *la zoccola_S del piano di sotto*
 the prostitute_{PEJ} of-the floor of down
 ‘the wh... living downstairs’
- b. **quella zoccola_E del piano di sotto di Carla*
 that EPITHET of-the floor of down of Carla

¹³ Note that the relevant part of the examples (33-34) is the first, where the antecedent of ellipsis occurs. For independent reasons, the elided part always requires the use of the weak demonstrative *quello*, irrespective of the type of elided DP.

¹⁴ Note that modification is allowed in epithets only if it is part of the epithet itself, thus forming a fixed expression. The most common case is *figlio/figlia di* ‘son/daughter of’ + prostitute_{PEJ}.

- (36) a. *il fascio_S biondo*
 the fascist_S blonde
 ‘the blonde fascist’
 b. **quel fascio_E biondo di Paolo*
 that EPITHET blonde of Paolo

In summary, the properties listed in Table 1 are transparently instantiated in Italian. The next step is to make sense of the occurrence of the mandatory use of the weak demonstrative. In §3.2, we show that it correlates with the underlying occurrence of an empty or elided nominal.

3.2 The correlation between empty nouns and epithets

Now, a question that arises from the Italian data seen so far concerns the use of a weak demonstrative with epithets. In particular, we would like to know why it is obligatory, and how the contrast with Spanish (cf. §2) can be accounted for.

A first observation we would like to make in this respect is that the contrast between Italian and Spanish in the distribution of demonstratives is not limited to epithets, but it is also found in cases of NP-ellipsis (cf. Leonetti 1999, Kornfeld and Saab 2004, Saab 2022a,b, Cardinaletti 2024, Pescarini 2024):

(37) Italian vs Spanish

- a. *la casa di Maria e {*/la/quella} <casa> di Carlo*
 b. *la casa de María y {la/aquella} <casa> de Carlos*
 the house of Maria and the/that house of Carlo
 Lit. ‘Maria’s house and the/that of Carlo’
 (38) a. *i libri che ho letto e {*/i/quelli} <libri> che ho venduto*
 b. *los libros que he leído y {los/aquellos} <libros> que he vendido*
 the books that have.1SG read and the/those books that have.1SG sold
 ‘the books that I’ve read and those that I’ve sold’

Examples (37-38) show that definite articles are ruled out in Italian, while the demonstrative *quello* is used without a “true” demonstrative import since it is not associated to any implicit or explicit act of demonstration and does not denote the canonical distal/non-distal semantic values of true demonstratives. In Spanish, on the other hand, both the article and the demonstrative *aquel* can be used, but here the use of *aquel* is clearly related with some distal value.

However, a closer inspection into Italian reveals that the situation is more complex than it appears at first sight: definite articles are not completely excluded from ellipsis environments.

Consider the following examples, in which the elided noun is followed by a possessive (39) or by an adjective (40):

(39) Italian

i libri miei e {i/quelli} tuoi
 the books mine and the/that yours
 ‘my books and yours’

(40) *la casa rossa e {la/quella} <casa> gialla*
 the house red and the/that <house> yellow
 ‘the red house and the yellow (one)’

These examples show that both the article and the weak demonstrative are used in ellipsis, but their distribution differs, depending on the word category of the element following the empty nominal anaphora (Cardinaletti 2024, Pescarini 2024).

The next question is thus what the exact distribution of the two elements is. We have already seen that articles are excluded when the following element is a PP (37) or a relative clause (38). In the case of possessives and adjectives, both articles and demonstratives are accepted (39-40).

However, the category of adjectives is particularly complex when it comes to NP-ellipsis. In general, articles are always acceptable in these cases, while the light demonstrative *quello* is ungrammatical in two contexts. The first is the case of [+human] silent nouns (Saab 2019), as witnessed by (41) (example taken from Pescarini 2024, but see also Cardinaletti 2024 for similar examples and judgments; capitals stand for silent nouns):

- (41) a. *I cani intelligenti e i <?cani>/PEOPLE> tonti sono indistinguibili.*
 the dogs intelligent and the dogs stupid.PL are indistinguishable
Lit. ‘Intelligent dogs and stupid <?dogs>/PEOPLE are indistinguishable.’
- b. *I cani intelligenti e quelli <cani>/*PEOPLE> tonti sono indistinguibili.*
 the dogs intelligent and that dogs stupid.PL are indistinguishable
Lit. ‘Intelligent dogs and stupid dogs/*people are indistinguishable.’

In these examples, the use of the article (41) favors an interpretation in which *tonti* ‘stupid’ is combined with a [+human] silent noun (corresponding to PEOPLE), so that *i tonti* is interpreted as “stupid people”. The ellipsis reading is usually less natural, but still available. By contrast, the

use of the weak demonstrative *quello* forces the ellipsis reading, while it is impossible to get a silent noun interpretation (41).¹⁵

The second context of NP-ellipsis in which only articles are possible concerns some specific classes of adjectives: ordinal numbers and adjectives like *stesso* ‘same’ (42):

- (42) a. *lo vivo al primo piano e lui {al/*a quello} secondo.*
 I live at-the first floor and he at-the/at that second
 ‘I live at the first floor, and he at the second.’
- b. *Maria ha comprato questo vestito al mercato e Lucia vorrebbe avere {lo/*quello} stesso.*
 Maria has bought this dress at-the market and Lucia would.like have the/that same
 ‘Maria bought this dress at the market, and Lucia would like to have the same.’

Note that when an adjective can be used with both an article and a demonstrative, there are usually slight semantic differences between the two. One notable difference is that the cluster ‘article + adjective’ can often be interpreted as a nickname, thus as a nominalization (in a similar way to slurs), while this is not the case when a weak demonstrative is used:

- (43) a. *Domani vedi il tuo amico senese o quello <amico> bolognese?*
 tomorrow see.2sg the your friend Senese or that <friend> Bolognese
 ‘Are you meeting your Senese friend or your Bolognese friend tomorrow?’ (ellipsis)
- b. *Domani vedi il tuo amico senese o il ____ norvegese?*
 tomorrow see.2sg the your friend Senese or the Norwegian
 ‘Are you meeting your Senese friend or the Norwegian tomorrow?’ (prevalent nickname reading)

In (43a), the only possible interpretation is that *amico* ‘friend’ has been elided in the second part of the conjunct: there are two friends, one from Siena and one from Bologna. In (43b), instead, the most natural reading is that *norvegese* ‘Norwegian’ is a nickname or, depending on the cases, a title. The second person mentioned in (43b), thus, needs not be a friend of the subject, nor really be from Norway: it is possible that the person got this nickname because of some physical or character trait, e.g., because he has very light blond hair, or because he is renowned

¹⁵ This makes sense if, as argued in Saab (2019, 2022a), human empty nouns are just empty concepts, with no indexical or elliptical ingredient. Note that in (41b) the empty noun interpretation is available if we use the “true” demonstrative, which in the case of the masculine plural is different from the light demonstrative: *quei tonti* ‘those PEOPLE stupid’ vs. *quelli <cani> tonti* ‘those.LIGHT stupid’.

as the best skier in town. The ellipsis interpretation is not completely ruled out in (43b), but it is less natural.¹⁶ Table 2 resumes the distribution of articles and demonstratives with empty nouns.

Table 2: Distribution of articles and demonstratives with empty nouns

Element following the empty noun	Use of article	Use of weak demonstrative
PP (37)	No	Yes
Relative clause (38)	No	Yes
Possessive (39)	Yes	Yes
Adjective (with silent nouns) (41)	Yes	No
Adjective (with indexical empty nouns and ellipsis)	Yes, with some categories (but prevalent nickname reading)	Yes, except for some categories of adjectives

4 Analysis

In this section, we first extend the analysis offered in (6) for Spanish to Italian (§4.1). In the same section, we follow Kornfeld and Saab (2004) and, more specifically, Cardinaletti (2024) and assume that the realization of the D as a weak demonstrative in Italian epithets is accounted for as allomorphic variation at the D head. In §4.2, we discuss qualitative binominals containing epithets in Italian with two aims. First, against the mainstream approach (den Dikken 2006), we claim that the qualitative word (i.e., the epithet) does not have any predicative import and, second, we critically review the recent proposal in Pescarini (2024), according to which there is a further correlation between qualitative binominals and other types of (pseudo)-partitive constructions. We contend that the similarities found in a variety of binominal constructions in which the preposition *di* ‘of’ is involved are not directly related to a partitive syntax but to, again, the underling presence of an indexical ingredient. In §4.3, we briefly discuss another type of Italian binominals, which do not require the demonstrative (i.e., the *cazzo*-construction). This fact leads to conclude that *cazzo*-binominals are not part of a pronominal structure suggesting a new taxonomy of qualitative binominal DPs, which includes two basic types, namely: (i) those that contain the indexical ingredient, and (ii) those that do not.

¹⁶ Note that there seems to be regional variation concerning the use of the article or demonstrative with adjectives in elliptical contexts, as in the case of epithets. From an informal survey with linguist colleagues, speakers from the North and Tuscany generally agree with the picture described here, while those from the South tend to use articles in more contexts in which an adjective is present. Thus, for them the ellipsis reading in (43b) might be more natural than (43a). If our analysis is on the right track, it is not a case that the same holds for epithets, where speakers from the South are more permissive in the use of the definite article (cf. fn. 2).

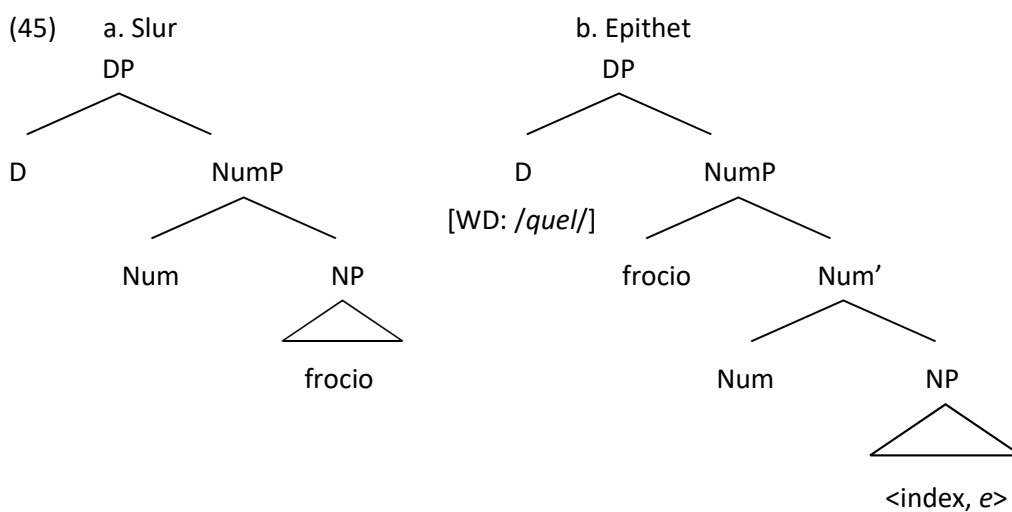
4.1 An indexical ingredient in Italian epithets

Consider again our initial minimal pair in (3-4), whose (a) examples we repeat in (44):

- (44) a. *Gianni è {il/questo/quel} frocio a destra.*
 Gianni is the/this/that homosexual_{PEJ} at right
 ‘Gianni is the/this/that f... on the right.’
- b. *Questo è {??il/quel} frocio di Carlo.*
 this is the/that EPITHET of Carlo
 ‘This is Carlo, the f...’

Following Saab (2022b, 2025a), we propose that Italian epithets involve an indexical empty noun with the epithet in the specifier of some functional projection of the DP (e.g., NumP). As already observed, since epithet constructions like (44b) are not compatible with the (limited) cases of empty nominal anaphora that allow the use of the article (cf. §3.2), they require the use of the weak demonstrative. In turn, slurs occur as canonical nominal predicates and do not show any special requirement on the realization of the D head, which can be instantiated by the full range of determiners in the language. Let’s focus first on simple DPs containing slurs or epithets and then on qualitative binominal constructions.

As we have seen in the previous section, the distribution of slurs and epithets robustly conforms to what we observed for Spanish and English in §2. Therefore, we propose a straightforward extension of the analyses provided in (6) for Spanish to Italian, with the minimal modification that the D head of epithet constructions is realized as a weak demonstrative (WD = weak demonstrative):



These analyses account for the distribution of slurs and epithets in the same way as in Spanish or English. As we have already shown, Test 1 on the anaphoric nature of slurs and epithets shows that epithets behave as antilogophoric pronouns and slurs as regular R-expressions. As the examples in (31) illustrate, in antilogophoric environments of the relevant type (i.e., those in which there is a Principle-C violation configuration), the predicative reading of slurs is blocked; in such environments, only the pure expressive reading of an epithet is preserved. The analyses in (45) explains the difference straightforwardly by virtue of the referential nature of each of the constructions under study here. Concretely, slurs are R-expressions, and epithetic constructions, antilogophoric pronouns. This is enough to explain why coreference is possible only under the epithet readings in the examples in (31): since epithets are pronouns, Principle-B is respected in the relevant syntactic contexts, which, in addition, avoid the antilogophoric constraint in (13).

Next, recall that Tests 2-3 on intensification and binominal occurrence disambiguate in favor of the epithetic reading in Spanish, English or Italian, while Tests 4-5 on nominal ellipsis and restrictive modification disambiguate in exactly the opposite direction, i.e., in favor of the slur reading. Since epithets in non-predicative, modification position are not the head of the entire DP, they allow for the intensifiers as other prenominal modifiers. As for the occurrence in binominals, as we will see in the next section, qualitative binominals are particular instances of the structures in (45b) with an additional equative coda. In the case of slurs, their licensing nominal ellipsis and restrictive modification is just a straightforward consequence of the fact that they are the predicative heads of the DPs in which they occur.

Now, the next question is how to account for the difference between, say, Spanish and Italian regarding the realization of the D head in the structure in (45b). In this respect, we follow the suggestions in Kornfeld and Saab (2004) and Cardinaletti (2024), according to which the occurrence of the weak demonstrative in Italian is resolved as a matter of allomorphic variation at the D node. Concretely, the alternation between the weak demonstrative and other possible competitors is sensitive to the empty nature of the nominal head. Cardinaletti notices that any of the configurations in (46), in which the heads are phonetically empty, triggers insertion of the weak demonstrative:

- (46) a. [_{DP} quelli [_{NumP} Num [_{NP} N_{human}]]]
 b. [_{DP} quelli [_{NumP} Num [_{NP} N_{index}]]]
 c. [_{DP} quelli [_{NumP} Num <[_{NP} N]>]] (Cardinaletti 2024: 13)

Yet, as Cardinaletti argues, things are more complex since the realization is also sensitive to the remnants/modifiers of the empty nominal head or empty NP (see also the previous section). So, the environments in (46) must be enriched in a way such as to introduce sensitivity to the

modifiers of the empty noun/elliptical site (see Table 2). We leave for another occasion a proper formulation of the allomorphic rule.¹⁷

In sum, the mandatory presence of the demonstrative with Italian epithets follows from the fact that indexical empty nouns and certain types of empty anaphora systematically require the presence of the demonstrative and reject the definite article, in particular with a non-adjectival category as remnant.

4.2 On binominals and weak demonstratives in Italian

Recall that qualitative binominals in Italian force the presence of the weak demonstrative, since they host an epithet:

- (47) *Ho visto {*il / quel} fascio del mio cugino*
 have.1SG seen the/that fascist of-the my cousin
 ‘I’ve seen my cousin, the fascist’

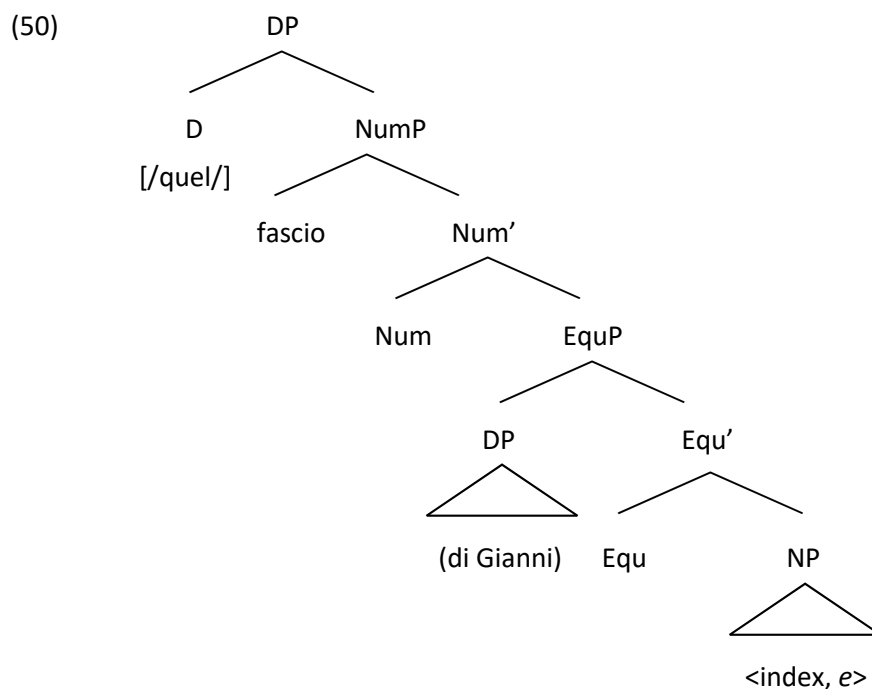
As it is well known, mainstream approaches to qualitative binominals in Romance and Germanic are conceived of as predicative structures with mandatory predicate raising (den Dikken 2006 and much related work; but see e.g. Massaro 2023 and Cavarani and Wyngaerd 2024 for interesting recent discussion). As argued in Saab (2022a,b), this is incompatible with the Pottsian approach to binominals pursued here. The main evidence in favor of a pure expressive analysis for epithets comes from our initial paradigm in (1) and (2), repeated below, which clearly shows that epithets do not have any predicative import, against the expectation of the predicate raising analysis:

- (48) a. *Andrés es puto.*
 Andrés is homosexual_{PEJ}
 ‘Andrés is a f...’

¹⁷ Note, however, that the situation of the distal demonstrative is even more complex than outlined by Cardinaletti, because a further factor that must be considered is the deictic or non-deictic value of *quel/quello*. In this respect, the uses of (46a-b) seem to carry a deictic value (since the distal demonstrative can alternate with the proximal demonstrative *questo* ‘this’, e.g. *quello/questo a destra* ‘that/this on the right’). This contrasts with the light demonstrative used in ellipsis (46c) and with the weak demonstrative used in epithets, which have no deictic value. Since a full analysis of the different uses and properties of the distal demonstrative is beyond the scope of this paper, we limit ourselves to the working hypothesis, which is based on Rizzi (1979) and Vanelli (1979), that the weak demonstrative forms are the results of a phonological rule that requires “shortening” of the long form when it is followed by an item with phonological content (in the case of the weak demonstrative, the epithet). The light demonstrative, on the other hand, cannot be shortened because the structurally closest item is a phonologically empty item, namely the elided N.

- b. *Ana es puta.*
 Ana is prostitute_{PEJ}
 'Ana is a *wh...*'
- (49) a. *Ese es el/ese puto de Andrés*
 that is the/that EPITHET of Andrés
 'That one is that *f...* Andrés'
- b. *Esa es la/esa puta de Ana*
 that is the/that EPITHET of Ana
 'That one is the/that *wh...* Ana.'

Here, we extend the analysis in Saab (2022b), according to which binominals are the surface reflex of an underlying equative syntax. On this analysis, the weak demonstrative realizes the node D under the conditions discussed in the previous section (i.e., use the demonstrative when the remnant/modifier of the empty indexical is not of (a certain) A category). Compared to the mainstream approach to binominals, these are not predicate raising structures but underlying equative constructions in which the *of*-phrase establishes an equative semantic relation with the empty indexical.



See Saab (2022b) for many analytical details and discussion of the predicate raising analysis. For our purposes here, it is important to make explicit how this analysis contrasts with the proposal

sketched in Pescarini (2024), according to whom the use of the light demonstrative in nominal anaphora derives from movement of the sequence [*Dem+remnant*] and further NP-ellipsis. Roughly, for a case like *quello bello*, Pescarini proposes the two steps in (51), in which the demonstrative is a light head of a reduced relative clause, which moves crossing the nominal head. Such a movement licenses NP-ellipsis.

- (51) a. *il libro [quello bello]*
 the book that nice
 ‘the nice book’
- b. [*quello bello*] <*libro*>
 that nice book
 ‘the nice one’

According to Pescarini, a set of (pseudo-)partitive constructions in Italian would give support to his analysis. In (52-54), there is a set of examples taken from Pescarini: (i) partitives (52), (ii) pseudo-partitives under direct modification (53), and (iii) inverse postnominal modifiers, including participial adjectives, coordinated or modified adjectives, PPs and CPs (54):

(52) Partitives:

- a. *tre (di libri)*
 three of books
 ‘three (books)’
- b. *nessuno (degli studenti)*
 nobody of-the students
 ‘no student/no-one’
- c. *poca (di pasta)*
 little of pasta
 ‘a little (pasta)’

(53) Pseudo-partitives under direct modification:

- a. *i più venduti (di libri)*
 the most sold of books
 ‘the most sold (books)’
- b. *il primo (di libro)*
 the first of book
 ‘the first (book)’

- c. *quelli (di libri)*
 those of books
 'those (books)'

(54) Inversed postnominal modifiers such as participial adjectives, coordinated or modified adjectives, PPs and CPs:

- a. *quello appeso (di quadro)*
 that hanging of painting
 'the hanging painting/one'
- b. *quello caro a papà (di quadro)*
 that dear to dad of painting
 'the painting/one that is dear to dad'
- c. *quelli sani e robusti (di alberi)*
 those healthy and strong of trees
 'the healthy and strong trees/ones'
- d. *quelle che ho visto (di case)*
 those that have.1SG seen of houses
 'those (houses) that I saw'

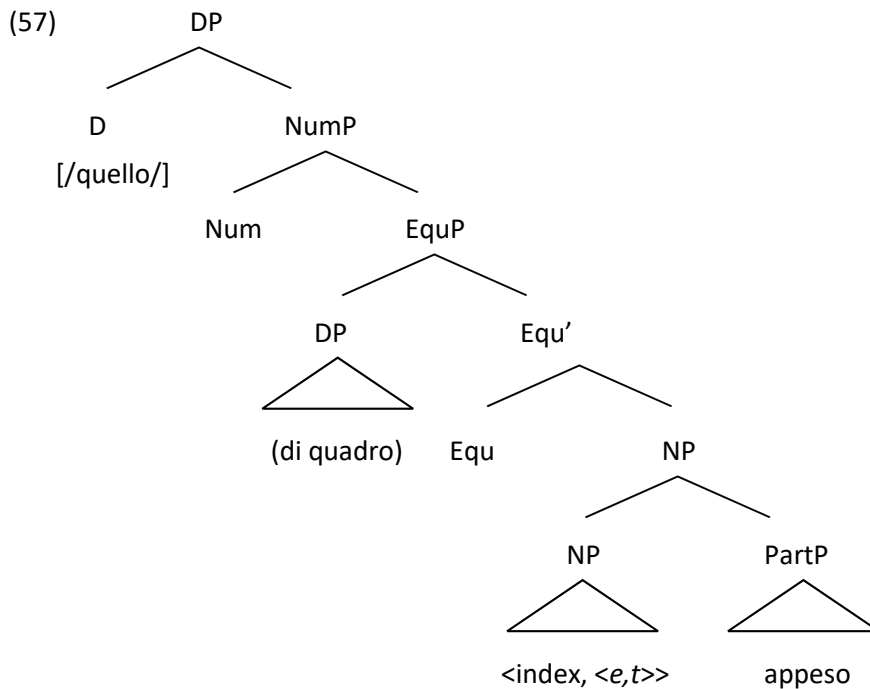
Interestingly, Pescarini also includes qualitative binominals as satisfying the relevant structural description:

- (55) a. *quel cretino di Giorgio*
 that idiot of Giorgio
- b. *quel genio di mio cugino*
 that genius of my cousin
- c. *quel vigliacco di un caporale*
 that coward of a corporal

For these qualitative binominals, he proposes a derivation along the lines of (51). Concretely, the [*dem+epithet*] phrase moves crossing the *di*-phrases, and this results in NP-ellipsis:

- (56) a. *quel cretino* <[di Giorgio > t]>
 b. *quel genio* <[di mio cugino t]>
 c. *quel vigliacco* <[di un caporale] t>

According to Pescarini, then, “NP-Ellipsis in Italian results when the *di*-phrase is not pronounced”. This correlation between partitives, qualitative binominals and nominal ellipsis has a long tradition in the Romance literature (Milner 1978 for a first formal approximation). One prevalent thought is that partitivity licenses ellipsis (Lobeck 1995 and Sleeman 1993, among others). We think that such a correlation is misleading in many respects. Semantically, a myriad of NP-ellipses simply lacks any (pseudo-)partitive semantics. Relatedly, binominals containing epithets also lack any partitive semantics.¹⁸ We conjecture that the right correlation is not between partitives and ellipsis licensing but between (pseudo-)partitives, qualitative binominals and indexicality. Put differently, what unifies the paradigms from (51) to (56) is the underlying presence of an empty indexical, whose semantic type can vary depending on the construction. For instance, for a case like (54a), the underlying structure is also equative, like in qualitative binominals, but with the crucial difference that its underlying index ranges over properties, not entities (57).



¹⁸ Note the contrast between (56), which are qualitative binominal structures with a weak demonstrative, and examples like (54), which feature a light demonstrative (cf. fn. 9). In addition, the structures in (54) have a focal component (e.g. in (54a) the hanging paintings are contrasted with others, which are not hanging).

We leave for future research a proper inquiry into this correlation.

4.3 Towards a new characterization of qualitative binominals in Italian

Before closing this study, we would like to make a brief observation on the Italian expressive term *cazzo* lit. ‘dick’, which behaves differently from epithets with respect to the use of the weak demonstrative (see Doliana 2016, Cuonzo 2019, Vanden Wyngaerd and Cavarani 2024, and Saab 2025a). Consider the following example:

- (58) *Ho lavorato tutto [il cazzo di giorno].*
 have.1SG worked all the.M.SG dick.M.SG of day.M.SG
 ‘I have worked all fucking day.’

As the English translation shows, the expressive *cazzo* is a good counterpart of expressive adjectives in English and other languages. There is ample evidence that both the syntax and the semantics of this type of expressives are different from the syntax and semantics of epithets (see Saab 2025a for discussion). On the one hand, the *cazzo*-construction, like expressive adjectives in English, shows argument extension effects (see Potts 2005, Gutzmann 2019, and Lo Guercio & Orlando 2022, among others), i.e., a type of syntactic-semantic mismatch in which the syntactic argument of the expressive does not match its putative semantic argument. In effect, the most natural reading is that *cazzo* denotes a certain emotional state of the speaker not with respect to days or the day at hand, but with respect to the semantic value of the entire proposition. In simplified terms, the sentence in (58) has the two meaning dimensions in (59), where the frowny face stands for whatever expressive meaning *cazzo* introduces:

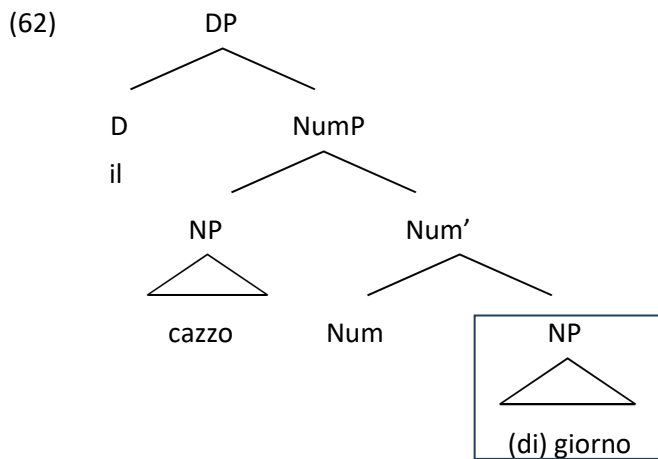
- (59) I have worked all day • 😞 (I have worked all day)

This is never the case with epithets, which always target the expected semantic argument.

On the other hand, syntactically, *cazzo* is invariably masculine and singular, regardless of the gender and number of the noun preceded by the preposition *di*. Furthermore, the complement of *di* is a bare noun, unlike with epithets (cf. (58) and (60-61) with (4)):

- (60) *quella cazzo di lettera*
 that.F.SG dick.M.SG of letter.F.SG
 ‘that fucking letter’ (Vanden Wyngaerd and Cavarani 2024: 340)
- (61) *quei cazzo di articoli*
 that.M.PL dick.M.SG of paper.M.PL
 ‘those fucking papers’ (Vanden Wyngaerd and Cavarani 2024: 341)

Now, to these peculiarities, we would like to add the observation that, unlike binominals containing epithets, the *cazzo*-construction does not require the use of the weak demonstrative, such as (58) illustrates – when a demonstrative is present, as in (60-61), it is a ‘true’ demonstrative with deictic import: this is shown by the fact that the proximal demonstrative *questo* ‘this’ can also be used in these examples, while it is excluded in qualitative binominals (cf. (25b)). A reasonable analysis, suggested already in Saab (2022a), is to assign to the complement of *di* (i.e., *giorno* ‘day’) the status of head of the entire DP, as shown below:



In this structure, *cazzo* forms a natural class with expressive adjectives and *giorno* projects the entire DP. Among other things, this explains why this nominal head is the true controller of gender and number agreement. On this view, following a suggestion already made in Pesetsky (2013), we can conceive the preposition *di* as the realization of the primeval case of all nominals, namely, genitive (although see Saab 2026 for recent discussion on the primeval genitive hypothesis in the domain of Spanish binominals).¹⁹

So, even if many details remain to be developed in full explicitness, we believe that there are plausible reasons to divide the taxonomy of expressive binominals into: (i) those that contain

¹⁹ As shown in Massaro (2023), the counterpart of the *cazzo* construction in Apulian, unlike Italian, does not make use of the preposition *of* in binominals.

(i) *l-a kaspata l-a bul:et:a* (Apulian; San Marco in Lamis, Foggia)
 DEF-F.SG freaking DEF-F.SG bill
 ‘that freaking thing of a bill’ (Massaro 2023: 146)

Variation in preposition insertion is not dependent on the grammar of particular expressive constructions, but on the way in which languages realize binominals in general. In this respect, as discussed in Massaro’s paper, Apulian allows absence of preposition not only in this expressive environment, but in genitive constructions as well.

the indexical ingredient, and (ii) those that do not. In this respect, if our argument in this study is correct, the distribution of weak demonstratives in Italian seems to constitute a robust test for diagnosing implicit indexicals in DPs.

5 Conclusion

Through this paper, we have successfully run and updated five tests to distinguish two classes of expressives in Italian, Spanish and English that confirm their diagnostic utility to detect mixed expressives (i.e., slurs) from pure expressive ones (i.e., epithets). Thus, this study has provided more data concerning the syntax-semantics interface from a multidimensional meaning perspective. But more specifically, our main contribution has been to offer a new piece of evidence for the syntactic activity of an indexical ingredient in epithetic constructions. In Jackendoff's (1972) terms, epithets are "special pronouns", in which a pronominal index is ornamented with a pure expressive word in the functional spine of the pronominal structure. Put another way, the mandatory presence of a weak demonstrative in Italian robustly confirms Jackendoff's original view on epithets. As we have shown, weak demonstratives in the language realize the D head whenever there is an empty nominal anaphora in the abstract structure (and other conditions apply).

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Abbreviations

E	epithet
PEJ	pejorative
S	slur

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